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Congress in grip of extreme disorder

Stasis, partisan split compound the dysfunction

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — It's August, which means members of Congress can only be in one place: at home in their districts, begging voters to let them keep their jobs.

It's never an easy task, and this year it's been particularly brutal. Historically high numbers of incumbents have lost in primaries for their seats or for higher office, and public disapproval of Congress is at record levels.

Part of the reason may be that it's not clear if lawmakers can legitimately claim to be even doing their jobs.

Congress has sunk to similarly historic levels of nonproductivity, partisan fighting, and general dysfunction. It's true in the statistics, it's true in the clear repudiation of Congress being delivered by voters, and it's true in the general malaise that current and former members of the institution express. But even if voters were to send many of them packing, it's not clear that would meaningfully improve the situation.

Congress has been locked in a sort of death spiral. Compounding effects of increased partisanship, decreased efficacy, and general malcontent fuel a self-perpetuating cycle in which the body becomes even less productive and uses less of its authority, and the public is rendered less impressed.

Although dysfunction and congressional unpopularity have

CONGRESS, Page A12

THE HARVARD LEGACY

THEY KNEW THEIR ANCESTOR FOUGHT IN THE REVOLUTION, BUT NOT WHO ENSLAVED HIM

STORY BY MIKE DAMIANO | GLOBE STAFF



ERIN CLARK/
GLOBE STAFF

In a confidential Harvard database, Joyce Barber is identified as A-01258. In Hingham, she is known as the keeper of her neighborhood's history.

She lives in a formerly Black enclave named after her ancestor, James Tuttle. The houses were once passed down through generations of shoemakers and shipbuilders. But over the past 40 years, the other families moved away. Now Barber is the last Tuttle in Tuttleville.

She keeps a 4-foot-long family tree she inherited from her mother in her living room. It is extremely detailed, but still incomplete. At 78 years old, she wants to fill in the tree's missing branches, to find all of her distant relatives who are, like herself, descendants of Native Americans, of enslaved peoples, of civil rights activists, and of veterans of nearly every major American war since the Revolution.

"I'm yearning to find out what happened to the other family members," she has said.

So it came as a shock when a Globe reporter walked up to her driveway recently and told her that the answers she sought had already been found.

Veronica Hodges stood inside her family's historic barn in Hingham. The barn has been in the family's possession for generations.

HARVARD, Page A14

On housing travails, a first-person object lesson

A journalist who covers the industry finds it's as difficult as advertised

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

It was a beautiful Thursday evening in April — one of those first sunny spring days that makes you remember why you live here — and I was running down the sidewalk in East Boston.

A few hours earlier, I had toured a distinctive apartment near Magoun Square in Somerville with my partner. I was expecting an email from the landlord any second, and my phone was about to die.

In Greater Boston's cutthroat housing market, nice, well-priced

apartments frequently go to one of two kinds of applicants: Those who make a boatload of money, or those who move fast.

So there I was, with neither a boatload of money nor sufficient sleep, weaving between pedestrians on Bennington Street, desperate to fill out an application be-

fore someone else did.

This is what it takes to find an apartment around here.

As The Boston Globe's housing reporter, I spend my professional life writing about Massachusetts' intractable housing problem, and how it warps the lives of so many

APARTMENTS, Page B5

Palette politics: GOP candidate's shades of blue

Minogue eschews the usual red in liberal Mass.

By Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

Michael Minogue is running for Massachusetts governor in a campaign bathed in blues.

The color dominates his lawn signs, campaign website, and, at times, his own clothes. Supporters can buy a cover for a spare wheel or a "lighthouse hoodie," each in different shades and accents.

In a video his campaign posted Thursday, Minogue — clad in a powder blue polo shirt — asks passersby to read a handmade sign and try to pronounce his name, when a woman tosses him a question: Is he a Republican or Democrat?

Given Minogue's preferred color palette, she may not be alone in wondering. Minogue is vying for the GOP nomination to face Governor Maura Healey in November. But experts in political branding said the Republican's embrace of a largely blue color scheme — typically signaling Democratic

MINOGUE, Page A13



Broadway, for the fun of it

Several shows are making for an uproarious season, writes Don Aucoin. N1.

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Globe Opinion continues its examination of problems with forensic science, this time looking at an arson investigation. Ideas, K1.

Maine visitors who take a road less traveled can

find the delightful seafaring town of Castine. Travel, N11.

Zillow's latest AI feature allows browsers to re-decorate a home virtually in their preferred style. Address, H1.

Dan Shaughnessy has some thoughts on next year's Pro Football Hall of Fame class. Sports, C1.

The Globe Magazine is not publishing today. The puzzles can be found on B8.



Outdoors, see

Sunday: Sun early. High: 84-89. Low: 65-70.

Monday: Partly sunny. High: 74-79. Low: 63-68.

Sunrise: 6:07 Sunset: 7:22

Complete report, A22. Deaths, A16-21.

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